

## Report Writing

This wiki section collects together information relating to writing the final project report. It is intended primarily for students on the MEng/BEng and MSc individual projects, as well as MSc students taking the Independent Study Option.

### Project Report

The project report is the long-term record of everything you have worked on. It should stand alone, without separate access to a presentation or any software produced. The markers rely heavily on the report to assess the overall quality of the project, especially the second marker and any moderators, as they will not have observed your regular progress on the project.

Writing a high quality report shows that:

- You can relate your choice of project, and the approach you take, to existing academic research and position this within the wider context of computing
- You can apply the theoretical and practical techniques taught on your degree programme to the problem you are addressing and that you understand their relevance to the wider world of computing.
- You are capable of objectively criticising your own work and making constructive suggestions for improvements or further work based on your experiences so far
- As a computing professional, you operate ethically and can explain your thinking and working processes clearly and concisely to third parties who may not be experts in the field in which you are working

**Please do not underestimate the importance of writing a high quality report.** Some students produce an excellent software artefact, but do not write this up to the same standard, and this is reflected in the final mark they achieve.

Ideally, you will write the report as you go along and review your writing with your supervisor. It is reasonable to ask your supervisor to review one chapter in detail, then to look at other chapters in overview. Please do not make the mistake of leaving your writing until the last minute, or expect your supervisor to be available to consider report drafts at short notice.

### Writing Style

Please use **UK English** (not US English) when writing up the report.

### Report Format

The maximum length for the final project report is **60 A4 pages of content**. We recommend that you leave a 2.5cm margin on all sides of the page, with a minimum font size of 11pt.

Content pages include all of your work within chapters.

They do not include the title pages, contents etc, reference list, or appendices.

You should not need to ever exceed this limit. Source code listings are submitted as part of your repo and do not need to be included in the report.

We expect all reports to be written succinctly and carefully edited. You are assessed on the quality of academic writing and the attention you pay to detail. In many cases, a 40 page report is better than a 60 page report. Reports that are unnecessarily padded will lose credit.

The physical layout of the report is important. Many supervisors will recommend that you use LaTeX for your report, although this is not a formal requirement. A tidy, well laid out, and consistently formatted document makes for easier reading and is suggestive of a careful and professional attitude towards its preparation.

Here are some templates:

[Template 1](#)

[Template 2](#) (thanks to Nuri Cingillioglu)

Note that Overleaf is used at your own risk and the software being unavailable for any reason would not be considered a valid mitigating circumstance.

A [separate LaTeX template](#) (originally produced for MSc students) is available as a downloadable archive.

A more recent [template provided by Jamie Willis](#) and hosted on Gitlab. This template is the version that is most actively being developed (please contact Jamie directly if you spot any issues).

Note that the older templates are imperfect and you are recommended to check the referencing format.

## **Referencing and Academic Integrity**

The Department uses the Vancouver referencing format.

Please **avoid plagiarism** in the report (and source code). Accidental plagiarism or not knowing how to cite and reference is not a valid reason for plagiarism.

We provide limited access to Turnitin to allow you to check your writing for accidental plagiarism. It is optional if you choose to use this tool or not.

## Report Submission

Please submit the report as a PDF document to **both Scientia and Turnitin**.

## Structuring the Report

The best structure for the report will vary from project to project. Please discuss the best format for your report with your supervisor.

[Previous distinguished and prize winning project reports are available to view](#) (where we have permission to publish them).

From the 2024-2025 academic year onwards, we have added a requirement for a [declarations section](#) to be included in the project report.

A project report will usually contain a number of chapters (Chapter 1, Chapter 2 etc). Each chapter contains Sections (2.1, 2.2 etc) and may also contain subsections (2.1.1, 2.1.2 etc).

The References, Declarations, and Appendices are not traditionally given chapter numbers.

## Sample Report Structure

It is suggested that you include the following components, but these may not map exactly to chapters.

**Title page:** This should include the project title, your name, and your supervisor name.

**Abstract:** The abstract is a brief summary (maximum 1 page) of the report's contents, including specific results and conclusions. It should make sense independently of the rest of the project. It should be no more than one page long. Somebody unfamiliar with your project should have a good idea of what it is about having read the abstract alone and will know whether it will be of interest to them. The abstract does not contain citations.

**Acknowledgements:** This is optional, but it is usual to thank your supervisor and other individuals who have provided particularly useful assistance, technical or otherwise, during your project.

**Contents pages:** This should list the main chapters and sections of your report, along with page numbers. Choose self-explanatory chapter and section titles.

**Introduction:** This is one of the most important components of the report. It should begin with a clear statement of what the project is about so that the nature and scope of the project can be understood by the reader. It should summarise everything you set out to achieve, provide a clear summary of the project's background and relevance to other work, and give pointers to the remaining sections of the report that contain the bulk of the technical material. You may wish to acknowledge ethical considerations here, but these will also be covered in the declarations.

**Literature review and related work:** This section of the report should set the project into context by relating it to existing published work that you read at the start of the project when your approach and methods were being considered. There are usually many ways of approaching a given problem, and you should not just pick one at random. Describe and evaluate as many alternative approaches as possible. The published work will usually be in the form of research papers, but you may also consider text books, technical manuals, or even existing software or hardware of which you have had hands-on experience. Acknowledge the sources of your inspiration; you are expected to have seen and thought about other people's ideas, so your contribution largely will be putting them into practice in some other context.

**Body of report:** The central part of the report typically consists of three or four chapters detailing the technical work undertaken during the project. The structure of these chapters is highly project dependent. Usually they reflect the chronological development of the project, e.g., design, implementation, experimentation, and optimisation, although this is not always the best approach. However you choose to structure this part of the report, you should make it clear how you arrived at your chosen approach in preference to the other alternatives documented in the background. For implementation projects you should describe and justify the design of your system at some high level, and should document any interesting problems with, or features of, your implementation. Integration and testing are also important to describe.

Some students working on more experimental projects choose to instead split this up with one chapter per experiment, including aspects of both development and evaluation within each chapter.

**Evaluation:** All projects need to contain a serious and careful evaluation of their results. The specifics of the evaluation method (e.g., user study, experiments, formal proof review, etc.) are intrinsic to the nature of the project, so this is something that you must discuss and agree with your supervisor early in the project. Ideally, a presentation of the method and results of your evaluation should be included in its own separate section of the report. Even the very best pieces of work have their limitations, so you are expected to provide a proper critical appraisal.

**Conclusions and future work:** All good projects conclude with an objective evaluation of the project's successes and failures, and suggestions for future work that can take the project further.

**References** (sometimes known as a Bibliography, but strictly speaking this is different): The References section consists of a list of all the academic papers, articles, manuals, etc., used in the project and referred to in the report. You should provide enough information to allow the reader to find the source. You should give the full title and author, and you should state where it is published, including full issue number, date, and page numbers where necessary. In the case

of a text book, you should quote the name of the publisher as well as the author(s). There is no excuse for incomplete references.

The Department of Computing referencing style is **Vancouver Referencing**.

**Declarations:** [See here](#)

**Appendices:** Appendices contain information that is peripheral to the main body of the report. The report should still make sense if the appendices are removed, and there is no guarantee that anything in this section will be read in detail or considered for marking. Often this is used to supply extra information that may be useful but would otherwise break up the flow of the text, for example tables, proofs and graphs. Please do not include source code listings as these will be available in your repo.

### **Academic Writing Support**

The [Centre for Academic English](#) provides on-demand courses, 1:1 support sessions, guided writing sessions, and other support with academic writing.